

JAYANT SINHA

GUEST COLUMN

INDIAN DEMOCRACY'S LESSONS FOR AMERICA

While every American presidential election is billed as history-making, this one genuinely belongs in that category. The very soul of America is at stake. It is at this fraught time that the world's largest democracy might have some pointers for the world's oldest democracy.

The American Declaration of Independence says: "*...all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty, and the pursuit of Happiness.*" These are the words that made America. For the past 250 years, the American democratic enterprise has striven to provide its citizens ever more equality and liberty. Americans believe that these words reflect a universal moral order.

Unfortunately, America's reality has often been at odds with these values. From the decimation of Native Americans, to the enslaving of millions of Africans, a brutal civil war fought to end slavery, the repression of non-whites till the 1960s civil rights movement, to the present day marked by shootings and racism—American democracy has been a constant struggle between reactionary power structures and ever-expanding notions of equality and liberty.

This is the struggle playing out in the 2024 presidential election. Today, close to 14 per cent of Americans are foreign-born, the highest since the 1890s. Hispanics are about 20 per cent of the population, African Americans 12 per cent, and Asian Americans about 6 per cent with over 5 million (about 1.5 per cent) of Indian descent. America's white Christian population will be a minority in two decades.

President Barack Obama's 2008 election, it seemed, had irrevocably redefined America as a multi-ethnic, multi-religious rainbow nation. Obama is half-white, born to a mother from America's heartland, Kansas. His father was a Kenyan economist. After Obama, all Americans, no matter what their ethnicity, could aspire to lead the country. Deep conservatism had been slayed, and America was truly an inclusive nation.

How wrong we were! Conservative America responded with the Make America Great Again (MAGA) movement, and Donald Trump defeated Hillary Clinton in 2016. Senator Clinton was poised to break the glass ceiling and be the first woman to become president. But the reactionary forces unleashed in America sought to protect traditional power structures. Recognising these impulses, the Democrats nominated Joe Biden, a white Christian male, in 2020. He indisputably won the election, but Trump (with violent support from MAGA forces) claimed the election was stolen from him.

In the past four years, the MAGA movement appears to have become even stronger. Trump has vanquished his Republican rivals. The movement is so deeply opposed to liberalism that they actually want to change America's constitutional framework. The right to abortion, established through the famous *Roe v. Wade* decision, is the best example. MAGA Christians believe that life begins at conception and deny women their reproductive freedom. Trump stacked the Supreme Court with three handpicked judges who promptly overturned the 1973 judgment.



This will be a fateful election for America. Will the daughter of Indian-Jamaican immigrants with a Sanskrit name and a Jewish husband become president?

Now, with President Biden's departure, a black woman has become the Democratic candidate. If Kamala Harris wins, she will pulverise the glass ceiling. She is also a Californian liberal from urban San Francisco brought up by two left-wing academics. The battle between reactionary and liberal forces in America has been joined.

This presidential election poses fateful choices for America. Are all Americans truly equal? Will Americans be ruled only by white Christian males or will the daughter of Indian-Jamaican immigrants with a Sanskrit name married to a Jewish man become president? Can American democratic institutions survive these polarising choices?

India's dharmic democracy offers some help as it is also based on a universal moral order. Our liberal Constitution guarantees equality, the full range of freedoms, non-discrimination, minority rights, due process, and reservations. All Indians have been able to attain all government positions. Our institutions are sworn to serve the Constitution rather than the powerful. India is committed to building an inclusive, liberal country.

America and India serve as twin beacons of freedom for the world. Our prophets of ahimsa and liberty, Mahatma Gandhi and Martin Luther King, have shown that it is our moral decisions that bend the arc of history. The Indian people have just voted. Now the American people must choose. ■

The author is a Distinguished Fellow at ORF and former Lok Sabha MP

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE